BRITISH SAILOR'S KIT

The "Jack Tar" in the age of Nelson was not issued with a uniform as such. Traditions in regard to dress were, however, so strong that the sailor's customary outfit of checked shirt, waistcoat, and short jacket made him instantly recognizable. Most of the sailors' duties revolved around sailing and maintaining the ship or firing its guns, so it was only when they boarded an enemy ship or their own ship was boarded that they were issued with cutlasses, pistols, and other weapons.

Jacket
Jackets were short with no tails and usually, but by no means always, blue. Sailors often bought material or clothes from the same outfitter or from the ship's purser, so there was considerable uniformity in their appearance.

Round hat
Sailors sported a great variety of headgear. Straw hats, popular in sunny latitudes, were often tarred to make them waterproof. The "round hat" had a tall crown rather like a top hat.

Brim, usually narrow

Shirt and neck cloth
Checked shirts were very popular and very much the hallmark of the sailor, whether serving in the Royal Navy or in the merchant marine. Equally emblematic was the neck cloth. This might double as a bandanna tied round the head to keep the sweat out of one's eyes when working in the intense heat of the lower decks.

Waistcoat
A colourful waistcoat was another more or less standard piece of clothing for British sailors. Being skilled at repairing sails, many of them were accomplished needleworkers, making and mending most of their own clothes.

Plain iron grip, painted black to protect it from corrosion

Guard consisting of two discs of thin iron

Cutlass
The model 1804 naval cutlass was a no-frills cut-and-thrust weapon. There was no call for sophisticated swordsmanship when fighting at close quarters or slashing away the enemy's rigging.

Spike could be driven into hull of enemy ship to make a step or handhold for climbing up

Axehead nailed to handle

Almost flat, straight steel blade